

PROMPT: REAL CASES OF DOMESTIC TAMPERING, AND WHAT THEY TEACH VIOLET'S STORY

2026-09-05. For ChatGPT (Stephen runs it; use a model with web search on) and for a fresh Fable agent (Claude runs it; Fable works from training knowledge and must say so where it is unsure). Both receive exactly the text below the line. Results are saved verbatim beside this file; nothing counts as considered until it is in a disposition table.

Operator context, not for the model: the first generation round (2026-09-03, twenty invented scenarios) produced nothing that stood out. Stephen's diagnosis: the yard and the unit are reachable by strangers or point at one key-holder, so the threat must be inside her house; and invented scenarios lack the texture of the real. This round grounds the search in documented cases first, then derives candidates from them.

You are researching for a true-crime mystery. Do this in two parts. Read everything before starting.

Part one: the real world

Find and summarise **eight to twelve documented real cases**, from any country and any decade, in which someone tampered with a victim's own home, or with an object the victim used in a fixed domestic routine, intending death or serious harm, where the tampering was designed to look like an accident or ordinary wear. Include both cases where it worked and cases where it failed or was discovered. Prefer cases where the tamperer was an intimate: a spouse, partner, relative, lodger, carer, close friend, or anyone with a key. Prefer cases where the method was mechanical, electrical, chemical, or structural rather than poisoning of food (one or two poisonings are fine if they are the domestic-routine kind).

For each case give, in plain prose:

- Where and roughly when, and the relationship between tamperer and victim.
- What was done, physically, in enough detail that a reader could picture it.
- What routine or habit of the victim's it relied on, and how the tamperer knew it.
- How it was discovered or how it succeeded, and what first made anyone suspicious.
- What the physical evidence was, and whether an ordinary observer would have read it as deliberate or as wear, accident or coincidence.
- One sentence on why it is instructive for fiction.

Cite each case by name or a searchable description. If you are working from memory and are not certain of a detail, say so plainly rather than invent it. Do not include cases involving children as victims. Do not dwell on gore.

Part two: what the real world teaches, applied

Now design **eight candidate scenarios** for the story below, each drawn from a pattern you found in part one (say which case or cases each one descends from). Real patterns adapted, not invented mechanisms.

The woman. Violet Moore, forty-four, a signwriter in a small coastal city. Fit, sharp, physically confident. She lives alone in a terraced house on Mariner's Row and works from a rented unit behind the fish market. She swims off the harbour slip most mornings, eats standing up, keeps her cash in a cookie tin in the house, ranks people's handwriting out loud, and is the last person in the city who would believe a friend meant her harm.

The four. Her closest friends. Liam holds a spare key to her house. Ruby, a nurse, is her Tuesday-morning friend. Margo does her books. Brad, a younger signwriter she taught for seven years, has a key to her unit, not her house. All four know her habits; nobody else in the city does.

Hard constraints on every candidate. Show how each is met.

1. The tampering is **inside her house**. Not the yard, not the street, not the unit, not the slip. Nothing a stranger could reach by climbing a fence or walking past. The whole evidence of intimacy is that someone was inside her home.
2. Access needed her house key or knowledge of where the spare lives, and knowledge of a habit only the four have watched. It must point at all four equally, not at the one who holds the spare.
3. It was aimed at her specifically, at something she does every day or every week, not at the house in general.
4. She survives it unhurt or barely hurt: a near miss, or a preparation she discovers before it is used. No falls, no stairs, no ladders. She keeps working and swimming afterwards.
5. When she inspects it she finds a physical detail that says deliberate rather than accident or wear: unscrewed not sheared, placed not fallen, present that should be absent or absent that should be present. She can keep it or photograph it.
6. To a competent police officer, and to any tradesman she might call, the same detail reads as nothing: old wiring, wear, a slipped memory. No lab could settle it in a day. There is no offence and no suspect. She knows how it would sound.
7. Had it worked, she dies, and a reader believes that without a paragraph of explanation. Not intimidation, not a prank, not a slow bet.
8. One tampering, not two coordinated ones. Nothing a reader has seen on television as the standard quiet murder.
9. It leaves her frightened enough to arrange for her own death without telling any of the four, and to write to them together rather than confront one.

For each candidate, in this order, plain prose, no headings inside it:

- The real pattern it descends from (which case in part one).
- The event, in two or three sentences, as it happens to her.
- The habit it exploited and why only the four know it.
- What she finds when she looks, and why it says deliberate to her.
- Why it says nothing to an officer or a tradesman.
- What she keeps or photographs.

- The one thing that would make it fail as story, named honestly.

Then a forced ranking of the eight, best first, one sentence per rank on why it beat the one below. No ties, no scores.

Write plainly. No em dashes.